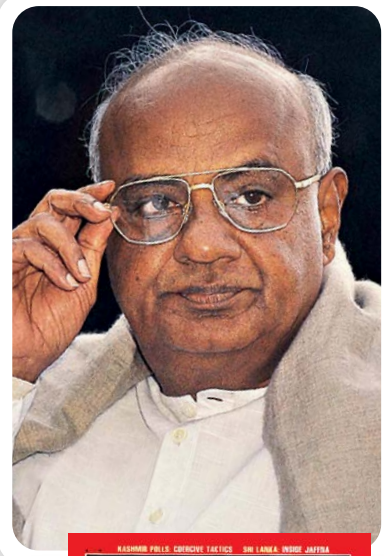
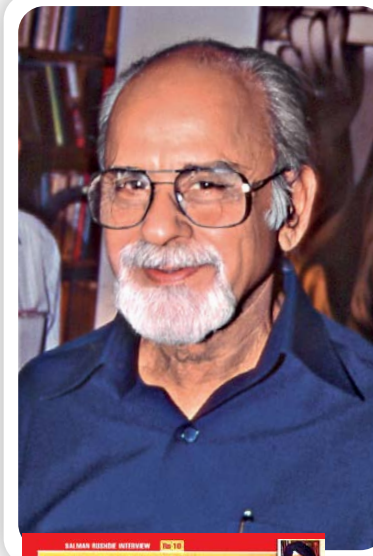
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PRASHANT PANJIAR



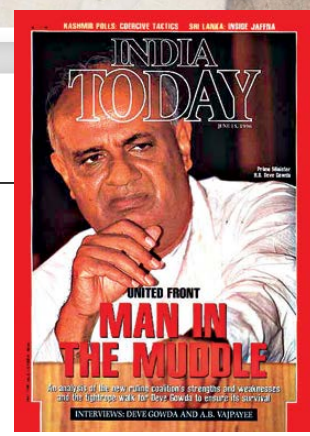
THE COMPROMISE
Karnataka farmer Deve Gowda and Indira-era durbari Gujral were unlikely candidates for the top job

As often in such situations, making a choice meant making a compromise.

Here, it took the unlikely shape of Gowda, a *raagi*-flavoured farmer leader from Karnataka. As the second PM from the South, northerners found him even more inarticulate than Rao, and an unfair share of derision came his way. But his reign, while brief, was creative enough. With its solid socialist-secular street cred, it cut a deeper swathe on reforms, with P. Chidambaram's 'dream budget' making bold tax reforms, and bringing in an ingenious voluntary scheme to reabsorb black money. Striking advances were also made on other fronts. The old Nagaland problem, for instance, saw a dialogue initiative that ended a long deadlock—the ongoing talks are essentially a continuation of that. Even the Delhi Metro was kickstarted then.

But the Congress had gone from pious protagonist to scheming puppeteer. Out went Gowda and in came Gujral, a safari-suited Punjabi, old Indira durbari and peacenik. His tenure, again cut short, came to be known for an eponymous foreign policy. The Gujral Doctrine now represents the pacifist end of Indian thinking, and entails shedding the hegemon-like approach to South Asia. The hawks saw it as terrible folly, a fundamental softness of character; the doves seek proof that the opposite has done any good. In the event, it had no chance to be tested under Gujral. An INDIA TODAY exclusive ousted him.

Vajpayee was back, for 13 months at first, then for five years—gaining longevity by borrowing the grammar of coalitions invented by the United Front. Foreign policy was again his signature domain, but it had a wider, nimbler vocal range: from Pokhran-II to peacemaking. A soft form of Hindutva permeated policy for the first time, education being a major focus. Reforms stabilised and sped up, especially on telecom and disinvestment. Signs of progress covered India's visage in the form of gleaming highways. For a time, it felt like the sun would never set on India Shining. Till the cardsharp up there dealt his last hand. This time, the architect of reforms, Manmohan Singh, was to get his turn under the sun. ■



Man in the Muddle
Jun. 15, 1996

"On balance, it would appear the advantage rests with Deve Gowda. If the Congress withdraws support and the Government collapses, it is the Congress that would be the biggest loser in a snap general election. The real beneficiary, of course, would be the BJP."



Meltdown
Jul. 14, 1997

"We can save it from others, but how can one save the party from its own leaders?" asks United Front convenor and Andhra CM N. Chandrababu Naidu incredulously. Others fear the split has left Gujral at the total mercy of the Congress."